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SPECIAL ISSUE ARTICLE

The Power of Play: Affective structures and the struggle for inclusion in education

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ABSTRACT

Play is often celebrated as a space of joy, creativity, and democratic learning. But what if play also excludes? This article contributes to the philosophy of education by rethinking play not as inherently liberatory, but as an affective and political practice, one that can both reproduce and resist systemic inequalities. Drawing on affect theory, feminist postcolonial critique, and critical pedagogy, the article argues that playful learning environments are shaped by affective architectures: circulating emotions, embodied histories, and normative assumptions that determine who feels safe, spontaneous, and seen, and who does not. Introducing the concept of affective scaffolding, we position inclusion not as a question of access but as a matter of emotional and relational design. Through two ethnographic vignettes, one of improvisational dissonance, the other involving a racially charged student performance, we trace how play can be a site of both hypervisibility and erasure. In response, we call for a radical reimagining of playful education that centers multiplicity, holds discomfort, and takes seriously the emotional labor of belonging. Rather than dismissing play's transformative potential, this article invites readers to feel forward, toward pedagogies that are sensuous, situated, and just.

KEYWORDS

Playful learning; affective scaffolding; affect theory; inclusion; philosophy of education; whiteness; postcolonial critique; educational justice; emotion in learning; playful institutions

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Introduction

This This article contributes to the philosophy of education by critically rethinking play as a site for both epistemic possibility and political struggle. In contemporary education, playful learning is increasingly promoted as a transformative alternative to traditional, linear, transmissive instruction (Nørgaard & Whitton, 2025; Nørgård et al., 2017; Whitton, 2022; James & Nerantzi, 2019). Rooted in curiosity, creativity, and experiential engagement, play disrupts conventional cognitive-dominant approaches by centering embodied, relational, and affective dimensions of learning (Henriks, 2009; Sutton-Smith, 2001; Mardell et al., 2016). While often described as a pedagogical modality, we broaden the frame, focusing on play as an existential, epistemic, ethical, and political force that extends beyond curriculum design into the affective structures of educational experience.

Within philosophy of education, Dewey (1938) foregrounds experiential learning as central to democratic education; Freire (1970) frames pedagogy as emancipatory dialogue; and Biesta (2013, 2015) argues for education that resists outcome-driven logics and cultivates subjectification. From this philosophical lineage, play emerges not merely as a pedagogical tool, but as a potentially generative mode of inquiry, relationality, and world-making.

However, the critical dimensions of play, its exclusions, affective politics, and historical entanglements, remain underexplored (Trammel, 2023). While often celebrated as inherently inclusive, fostering low-stakes engagement, openness, and co-creation (Dowd & Thomsen, 2021; Zosh et al., 2018; Kangas et al., 2023; Koeners & Francis, 2020), play is not free from social structuring. It is never neutral. Critical and affective scholarship shows play as embedded in, and productive of, affective hierarchies, cultural imaginaries, and systems of power. It structures not only what can be known or done but also who is welcomed, how joy circulates, and whose dissonance is rendered illegible (Trammel, 2023; Ahmed, 2004; Skriver, 2023; Skriver & Jensen, 2024).

In Nordic educational contexts, playful learning sits within progressive, egalitarian ideals. Yet these ideals coexist with unmarked whiteness, assumptions of neutrality, and narratives of cultural innocence that obscure exclusion (Wekker, 2016; Skriver, 2023; Becher, 2018). For some students, racialized, refugee, or otherwise minoritized, what appears as low-stakes or "fun" for peers can register as affectively dissonant, alienating, or even harmful (Trammel, 2023; Skriver, 2024). As Sara Ahmed (2007) reminds us, emotions do not reside in individuals but circulate within social fields, shaping who feels "at home" and who must navigate atmospheres of discomfort.

We use belonging to denote both an affective condition and relational accomplishment, the felt sense of being held within the rhythms and attentional economies of a community (Ahmed, 2004). Belonging arises through recognition, spatial arrangements, and temporal rhythms, not through access alone. We approach whiteness as an affective orientation and infrastructural norm (Ahmed, 2006, 2007): a background alignment of expectations, humor, spontaneity, and comportment that appears neutral while shaping who moves with ease. In the Nordic context, it does not merely accompany national "innocence" (Wekker, 2016); it sustains it, rendering racialized discomfort invisible within playful learning's rhetoric of openness (Skriver, 2024).

As Trammel (2023) argues, even seemingly joyful and collective forms of play, such as Pokémon GO! can operate within racialized affective economies, inviting some players in

while exposing others to surveillance, violence, or exclusion. To design just and joyful futures, we must attend to the affective contours of learning and the plural bodies and histories it enfolds (Hickey-Moody, 2013; Morrison et al., 2023; Zembylas, 2013, 2020; Skriver, 2023; Skriver & Jensen, 2024; Skriver, 2024a, 2025). These insights reverberate in educational settings, where play's assumed universality often masks its structuring exclusions. Rather than dismissing play's affirmative potential, this article embraces its ambivalence, approaching it as a site where joy and exclusion, hope and surveillance, improvisation and control coexist in tension.

To reimagine play as an affective force for inclusive education, we introduce the concept of *affective scaffolding*, the intentional design of emotional, social, and material support structures that enable students to enter play on their own terms. Affective scaffolding foregrounds difference, centering lived affective experiences and embodied histories and attends to the affective attachments of those often marginalized within dominant pedagogical models. This idea resonates with visions of the playful university (Nørgård & Whitton, 2025), which frame institutions as relational and caring spaces that foster curiosity, belonging, and plural participation. Rather than treating play as an isolated pedagogical tool, such approaches call for a rethinking of the entire educational ecology, including how institutions cultivate affective and democratic conditions for playful learning. It also resonates with Rancières (1991) concept of dissensus, framing play as a site of affective contestation, where conflict, difference, and dissonance are not disruptions but integral to the learning experience. Finally, it echoes Biesta's (2013) insistence that education must remain open to encounters with otherness, not as something to be managed, but rather as something to be affirmed and engaged.

This article addresses the following research questions:

1. *How do emotions and affect shape learning encounters in playful spaces?*
2. *How do power, whiteness, and nationalism shape playful learning environments, reinforcing inclusion and exclusion?*
3. *How can educators create affective scaffolding to foster inclusive playful learning?*

While affect has increasingly been recognized in education, we foreground how it operates specifically in playful learning. We build on the call to "feel forward," approaching educational futures not only through rational critique but through affective, relational, and imaginative engagement. In doing so, we argue that play, often celebrated for its inclusivity and joy, must also be understood as an affectively structured and politically charged practice, one that requires intentional scaffolding to be genuinely inclusive. Only when attentive to power, history, and embodied difference can play serve as a site of radical joy, critical hope, and justice-to-come.

Building on the argument that play is structured by affective and political forces, we revisit two vignettes from the first author's PhD research (2020-2023) in Denmark. The vignettes trace how affect circulates unevenly in educational spaces, shaping who is welcomed into play and who is marked as out of place, and how assumptions of neutrality and universality can conceal exclusion.

We draw on a post-qualitative, affect-focused ethnography in the Social Education Studies Program at a Danish University College (2020-2023) conducted within the national

Playful Learning Research Extension Program. The study examined how playful pedagogies were designed and experienced in everyday teaching. Materials included (a) naturalistic observations, (b) collaborative arts-based sessions, (c) semi-structured interviews with students and educators, and (d) fieldnotes attending to atmospheres, rhythms, postures, and micro-affects. Guided by concepts such as *affective arrangements* (Slaby, et al., 2019), *white innocence* (Wekker, 2016) *whiteness* (Ahmed, 2007), and *orientations* (Ahmed, 2006), analysis iteratively traced how bodies, objects, spaces, and norms conditioned participation and belonging. Ethics included informed consent, ongoing assent in arts-based sessions, anonymization, and composite vignette construction where necessary. The vignettes adapt published analyses (Skriver & Jensen, 2024; Skriver, 2023) and serve as an anchor for the article's theoretical exploration.

The article unfolds across four sections: Section 2 elaborates affective arrangements and atmospheres; Section 3 examines how whiteness, nationalism, and colonial legacies operate within playful learning; Section 4 develops affective scaffolding as a framework for inclusive participation; Section 5 concludes with implications for educational philosophy and the design of just, plural learning futures.

Theoretical Orientations: Affective Architectures of Belonging and Exclusion

Play is not simply an activity (Sutton-Smith, 2001); it is an embodied, relational encounter shaped by histories, habits, bodies, and the emotional contours of the spaces in which it unfolds. In playful classrooms, laughter, movement, and informality can appear universally welcoming while presupposing an "ideal" playful subject, one who is extroverted, culturally attuned, and comfortable with exposure. When these infrastructures go unexamined, participation narrows and exclusions recur (Ahmed, 2004; Krueger, 2021; Skriver & Jensen, 2024).

In Nordic classrooms, assumptions of ease can obscure how prior experience and cultural codes regulate ease and friction, and shape entry. Giæver (2023) shows that inclusion in multicultural early-childhood settings is often filtered through majority understandings of community that, paradoxically, reproduce exclusionary boundaries. Similarly, Kalkman & Clark (2021) find that newcomer children's roleplay shows access hinges on tacit social codes, an analogy for higher education where improvisation rewards fluency in dominant affective grammars. Such findings illuminate the affective undercurrents of play, reminding us that participation is never only a matter of skill or willingness but of emotional attunement (Mühlhoff, 2019). This returns us to the question of affect itself, how it organizes inclusion and exclusion in educational life.

Affect, as Ahmed (2004) reminds us, is not just something felt between individuals; it circulates between bodies, accumulating on certain subjects and saturating spaces with social meaning. This is also supported by Karoff (2013, p. 8) who states that play is not a state that originates within the individual or is imposed from outside; it emerges through the ongoing engagement with the activity itself and with others who participate. In this sense, play is a relational process through which new meanings and possibilities arise. Play is also a relational field that regulates participation by calling for alignment with often unspoken

affective norms. To play is to navigate these affective orientations, to find one's bearings within a space already organized by expectations of ease, spontaneity, and belonging.

We adopt *affective arrangements* (Slaby et al., 2019) to name the patterned configurations of emotions, bodies, materialities, and power that shape how encounters unfold. These arrangements are sedimented through institutional norms, cultural imaginaries, and embodied histories (Slaby et al., 2019). In playful learning, affective arrangements define spatial, relational, and sensory cues that guide participation—how laughter is shared, how movement is negotiated, and whose voices carry. Their atmospheres (Slaby et al., 2019; Riedel, 2019) may seem open and egalitarian, yet they are often underpinned by unmarked assumptions about the "ideal" playful subject: informal, extroverted, embodied in particular ways, and culturally attuned to dominant norms.

Building on Ahmed's (2006, 2007) work on *orientation* and *whiteness*, we understand such arrangements as also structured by affective orientations, habitual alignments that shape who moves with ease and who must continually reorient themselves within the space. These orientations are not merely personal dispositions but structural tendencies that produce comfort for some and friction for others. In Nordic contexts, they often intertwine with what Wekker (2016) calls *white innocence*, the national self-image that sustains a sense of openness while disavowing the racial and colonial histories that underwrite it. When these affective infrastructures (Berlant, 2016) remain unexamined, play risks reproducing the very exclusion it seeks to resist (Skriver & Jensen, 2024; Skriver, 2023).

These dynamics become most visible when traced through concrete moments of lived experience. In what follows, two vignettes are critically revisited (Holman Jones, 2016): one involving an embodied moment of discomfort in a classroom improvisation, the other centered on a racially insensitive student performance. These vignettes do not illustrate isolated failures but expose how affective arrangements regulate who is invited into play and who is excluded. They offer insight into how such arrangements position students differently.

Affective Economies of Play: Who Feels at Home?

In Nordic settings, play is frequently framed as a low-stakes, universally accessible mode of learning (Skovbjerg et al., 2024). Play-based learning is rooted in cultural traditions that assume a shared sense of humor, bodily engagement, and informality. Educators may assume that playfulness fosters a "safe" and open space for all learners (Nørgaard & Whitton, 2025). Yet this assumption elides how histories, norms, and experience shape who feels at ease, who experiences friction, and who must navigate discomfort, adaptation, or outright exclusion (Ahmed, 2004; Krueger, 2021). For students from racialized, refugee, or religious minority backgrounds, these norms can create affective barriers to participation (Skriver & Jensen, 2024).

The following vignette highlights how such affective economies shape experience in subtle but consequential ways.

Vignette A: Discomfort and Delay—At the Margins of Play

In a drama-based unit designed to foster spontaneity and embodied expression, a Kurdish woman from Syria, training to become an early childhood educator, found

> *herself on the margins of play. Although she identified as an "open person," her participation in improvisation was marked by hesitation. The activity required students to engage in unscripted, bodily interaction with peers, something her white Danish classmates embraced with laughter and performative energy. In contrast, she remained still, observing at the periphery rather than acting.*
>
> *Her discomfort did not stem from religious or cultural restriction; she explicitly distanced herself from those assumptions, stating that she eats pork, drinks alcohol, and is comfortable engaging across gender lines. Her reticence, rather, was a response to affective dynamics: she did not feel the space had made room for her presence. "I'm not holding back," she said, "but I'm reading how they react. I listen a lot..." Her posture revealed not refusal, but cautious negotiation—an attempt to discern whether the play space could hold her difference without requiring its erasure. Though she believed in play's inclusive potential, her embodied experience told another story: one of hyper-visibility, emotional vigilance, and the need to delay until safety could be sensed.*

This instance illustrates how the "open" atmosphere of play can be experienced as deeply exclusive—an atmosphere that regulates not only who is invited to play but how, when, and on what terms. What appears light-hearted to some may, for others, be dense with unspoken affective demands. Participation, in this context, is not merely a matter of willingness but of navigating a terrain already shaped by cultural assumptions, embodied norms, and histories of exclusion. Rather than a shared play space, the exercise becomes a site of negotiation, where some students move with ease and recognition, while others encounter friction, hyper-visibility, or the pressure to assimilate. It is in these tensions that the politics of play become most legible, and where the need for intentional affective scaffolding becomes most urgent. The tensions visible in this vignette illustrate how whiteness operates as an unmarked affective norm, structuring ease, spontaneity, and belonging. What feels like neutral play to some is experienced by others as a demand for alignment. This dynamic recurs in other classroom encounters, revealing how whiteness organizes the affective possibilities of participation.

Whiteness as an Unmarked Affective Norm

The assumed neutrality of play is further complicated by the ways whiteness operates as an unmarked affective structure. In Nordic playful learning, whiteness often functions as the default affective orientation (Ahmed, 2006, 2007): a structuring force shaping how bodies move, what is felt as comfortable of disruptive, and whose emotions are taken seriously. In playful pedagogy, it defines what is legible as "fun," "appropriate," or "creative". Expectations around humor, spontaneity, and informality are culturally specific yet often treated as universal (see also Skriver & Jensen, 2024). When white students improvise with confidence and treat play as neutral, this reflects not only personal ease but histories of pedagogical familiarity and social legitimacy. In *Vignette A*, delayed entry is not deficit but protective calibration in the face of norms that privilege those already attuned to dominant orientations. Yet students who fall outside these orientations are more likely to experience dissonance or exclusion, even when engaging in the same pedagogical tasks.

The following vignette illustrates how whiteness, when left unexamined, becomes an affective infrastructure that supports ease and alignment for some while rendering others out of sync, silenced, or erased (ibid.). In this way, play does not merely express cultural narratives, it enacts and reinforces them, shaping the affective contours of inclusion and exclusion in educational spaces.

Vignette B: Affectively Misaligned—A Performance of Whiteness

During a drama-based play building unit in a Danish University College, a group of white-identifying students staged a performance meant for a child audience. The scene they devised drew from a Danish children's song about Jamaica and involved dressing up as "exotic islanders," wearing braided wigs, brown-painted masks, brown long sleeves and grass skirts over brown leggings, and exaggerated tropical island dance moves. The students danced joyfully, visibly enjoying themselves and embodying the characters with theatrical enthusiasm. The affective atmosphere in the room was light, playful, and affirming—for some.

Yet the performance was also deeply racialized. It recycled colonial stereotypes, resurrecting visual tropes of the "exotic other" embedded in Nordic childhood media and literature. The performers appeared unaware of the racial implications of their enactment. The instructors, meanwhile, focused on aesthetic delivery—music, costume, and bodily expression—without addressing the content or its implications. No one publicly objected. The silence in the room was not neutral but indicative of an unspoken consensus, what Wekker (2016) calls "white innocence"—a disavowal of racism that allows whiteness to remain comfortable, unmarked, and untouched.

As the performance unfolded, the researcher present experienced growing discomfort, alienation, and affective dissonance. While the group moved in rhythm, literally and emotionally, she became what Ahmed (2010) terms an "affect alien," unable to align with the dominant mood. The pleasure circulating in the room rendered the racialized nature of the performance invisible to most but hyper-visible to those differently situated. The racial affect generated by the scene was not incidental; it was part of what made the performance "work."

Here, racialized caricature became a shared object of enjoyment for the dominant group, an affective glue that sustained collective ease (Ahmed, 2010). This ease, however, came at a cost: it depended on the erasure of discomfort, the silencing of critique, and the assumption that everyone present shared the same emotional orientation toward the performance. For racialized students, if present, the atmosphere of ease may have registered instead as alienation, harm, or the need to quietly endure. Thus, the moment exposes how playfulness can operate as a form of affective governance, reproducing whiteness as the unmarked norm and rendering dissonance illegible within the sanctioned affective economy of the classroom.

The Magic Circle as a Porous Boundary

Game scholars have long used the term "magic circle" to describe a temporary space of suspended reality create by play (Huizinga, 1955; Salen & Zimmerman, 2004). As Trammell (2023), Whitton (2018, 2022), and Skriver (2023; 2024a) argue, this boundary is not experienced equally by all. Skovbjerg & Sand (2022) contend that foundational thinkers such as Huizinga, Bateson, and Goffman recognize internal logics, rules, and frameworks that structure meaning for participants within the play frame. In this frame, actions take on specific meanings that make sense *within* the play context, even if they might not make sense outside it. At the same time, Skovbjerg & Sand (ibid.) note that those orders of meaning, the frameworks and rules that structure play, are often conceptualized as distinct from everyday reality. Yet the supposed suspension of reality frays when identities remain hyper visible or when play invokes painful cultural histories. The ability to step into the "magic circle", to feel held by its atmosphere, depends on more than willingness or imagination. Participation does not mean leaving everything behind; the social world crosses that threshold with us (Skriver, 2023, 2024b; Skriver & Jensen, 2024, Skriver). As the boundaries between play and everyday life blur, the circle becomes a permeable site of negotiation. Entry thus depends on a sense of affective safety, or a sense of being emotionally and socially supported enough to risk exposure. Such safety is unevenly available across hierarchies of race, class, gender, and ability. Our cases make visible how everyday hierarchies seep into play and shape who can "let go."

For instance, while some white Danish students may slip easily into an improvisational exercise, a student with refugee experience might be inhibited by memories of forced performance or hyper-surveillance (Skriver & Jensen, 2024). The invitation to "let go" presumes equal footing; in practice the "magic circle" is an affective border—a threshold that grants ease, spontaneity, and belonging more readily to some than to others. As Skovbjerg & Sand (2022) argue, play must be understood as entangled with the ecologies of everyday life, norms, values, and power dynamics do not stop at the border of play space but move through it. This means that the "magic circle" is not a sealed-off sanctuary, but a porous and contested terrain shaped by wider social relations; interaction and interrelatedness continuously spill across its boundary. In this view, play is not exempt from hierarchy or exclusion; rather, it is a space where these forces are felt and negotiated.

Affective Inequity and the Hidden Politics of Play

Critical theorists emphasize that play is always structured by power (Trammell, 2023). It is embedded in affective economies (Ahmed, 2004), circulations of emotion and value, that structure who belongs, who is excluded, and which forms of participation are legitimized (Trammell, 2023; Skriver & Jensen, 2024). In playful learning environments, these dynamics are shaped not only by pedagogical design but by unmarked norms of whiteness, nationalism, and Eurocentric assumptions of "neutrality". Such norms frequently operate invisibly, yet powerfully, delimiting who feels at ease, who is disciplined, and who is seen as out of place.

In the Nordic context, playful learning is tightly interwoven with national imaginaries of progressiveness, egalitarianism, and child-centered education. However, these self-understandings can obscure the racialized and colonial conditions under which such ideals

have developed and still operate. Whiteness, in particular, functions not just as a social identity but as an affective infrastructure (Berlant, 2016), organizing who feels at ease, who must perform belonging, and who is positioned as the stranger to the game. When Nørgaard & Whitton (2025) invite us to "dare to dance with the unknown" (p. 295) the point is not to transcend politics but to amplify taken for granted truths and allow them to be contested. Play does not unfold in a neutral arena; it is a venue where values, histories, and attachments are negotiated. Recognizing this is essential if we are to understand how play can both reproduce and resist social exclusion.

Read together, the two vignettes clarify how whiteness organizes affective participation in distinct but connected ways: in *Vignette A*, careful reading and delayed entry signal self-protection within unfamiliar norms; in *Vignette B*, racial caricature is rendered "just play," exemplifying Wekker's (2016) notion of white innocence, where national self-images disavow racism while reproducing its effects.

The Affective Grammar of Whiteness

Having outlined whiteness as an unmarked affective structure, we now trace how this structure materializes in practice, how it feels, moves, and organizes participation in concrete pedagogical scenes. Whiteness operates not only as a racial identity but as what Ahmed (2007) describes as an affective orientation, a structuring force that shapes how bodies move through space, what is felt as comfortable or disruptive, and whose emotions are taken seriously. In playful pedagogy, expectations around shared affective dispositions, such as humor, spontaneity, informality, which are culturally specific, are often treated as universal (see also Skriver, 2023). This produces what Leonardo (2009) calls whiteness as an invisible norm, a background orientation that does not name itself yet governs the terms of participation.

When white students improvise with confidence and treat play as neutral, this reflects not only personal ease but histories of pedagogical familiarity, cultural attunement, and social legitimacy. In the Syrian student's improvisation (Vignette A), discomfort is not deficit but protective calibration in the face of norms privileging those already aligned with dominant affective orientations. Similarly, the ease with which white Danish students enacted "exotic" caricature in a performance (Vignette B) reveals not simply a lapse in awareness but an inherited affective grammar of play, where racialized tropes can be rendered innocuous, even entertaining. In both cases, white students' confidence is scaffolded by historical narratives and institutional norms that frame their forms of participation as standard, while marginalizing or misreading others' dissonance as resistance or failure.

These affective structures help explain why racialized refugee students may experience play as confusing, embarrassing, or even hostile. As Britzman (1998) reminds us, pedagogy is about emotional investments and resistances as much as knowledge. When play is compulsory and unexamined, it risks reproducing what Gunaratnam (2003) terms emotional normativity, the expectation that students will feel a certain way (joy, ease) or be marked deviant if they don't. Skovbjerg and Sand (2022) challenge romanticized views of play, showing it to be a contested social field shaped by ongoing negotiations of inclusion and exclusion. Seen in this light, play is not exempt from the everyday dynamics of power,

it is where such dynamics are often intensified, especially when participants are differently positioned in relation to dominant affective expectations.

This normativity is entangled with broader national narratives. In Denmark and other Nordic countries, egalitarian and student-centered self-images can mask racialized conditions of belonging. Danbolt and Myong (2019) describe "racial exceptionalism" wherein racism is disavowed while belonging is quietly regulated through whiteness and cultural sameness. In educational spaces, this becomes affective labor for minoritized students: expectations to perform ease, openness, and playfulness even when conditions for genuine affective engagement are not met. Honig's (2009) account of democratic foreignness is helpful here. The democratic "we" is often sustained by positioning some bodies as foreign to be assimilated or disciplined. In playful learning, calls to "just play along" can mask deeper affective coercion (Skriver, 2023): demands to disavow discomfort, suppress difference, and conform to normative orientations and tempos of participation. When play invokes cultural archives that reproduce racialized tropes, as in blackface-adjacent performances, non-intervention is not neutrality but an active affective arrangement keeping whiteness comfortable and dissent unsayable (Wekker, 2016; Skriver, 2023).

These dynamics expose the limits of assuming that play is inherently inclusive. As Manning (2009) argues, participation turns on conditions of entry, timing, tempo, bodily readiness. For many students, entering play involves navigating dissonance, mistrust, or unfamiliar cultural scripts. The assumption that students can "just play" reflects what Lewis (2013) critiques as the myth of educational neutrality: the belief that learning spaces are open to all, when they, in fact, shaped by histories of exclusion and erasure.

Affective Scaffolding: Designing for Plural Entry into Play

Creating inclusive playful learning requires more than an open invitation. Inclusion depends on affective conditions that make meaningful engagement possible. This section introduces the concept of *affective scaffolding* as a critical response to the normative assumptions of playful learning: that it is inherently democratic, low-stakes, and universally accessible. We define affective scaffolding as the intentional shaping of emotional, social, and material supports that enable students to enter play on their own terms. It recognizes that participation is shaped by histories of racialization, cultural exclusion, trauma, and the embodied sedimentation of power. Scaffolding legitimizes slowness, silence, hesitancy, and refusal (Zembylas, 2013; Trammel, 2023) and resists emotional normativity that equates success with visible exuberance. Rather than guiding students toward a fixed goal, scaffolding curates the conditions that invite relation, pause, and multiplicity. It is a practice of affective justice (Zembylas, 2013): a refusal of pedagogical neutrality, and an embrace of the emotional labor required to build spaces of belonging.

To better understand how such scaffolding takes shape in practice, we turn to *we-spaces*: affectively attuned, playful learning environments that build belonging through atmosphere, rhythm, and sensory care (Kreuger, 2021; Skriver, 2024b). These spaces offer an embodied, material illustration of what it means to scaffold inclusion, not just as a matter of access, but of emotional and relational possibility.

Expanding the Emotional Range of Play

Much of the literature on playful learning equates inclusion with openness or fun. Yet joy, improvisation, and spontaneity are not universally accessible or safe. For many students, play can evoke exposure, hyper-visibility, vulnerability, or even fear. While Nørgård & Whitton (2025) emphasize relational pedagogy and care, we extend that vision by proposing that affective scaffolding must also expand what counts as legitimate affective participation. Drawing on Trammel (2023), Zembylas (2013), and Hickey-Moody (2013), we argue for accommodating hesitancy, slowness, silence, and refusals as valid ways of being with others.

This is not a rejection of play's affirmative potential, but an insistence on its complexity. It asks for a broader repertoire of playful expressions, and the ability to explore other ways of expressing oneself. As Nørgård and Whitton (2025) put it, "the playful university is anything but universal" (p. 298). Play can be joyful, but only when it is not compulsory. Play can also be liberating, but only when it does not demand conformity to affective norms.

Affective scaffolding broadens the emotional repertoire of play so that students are not forced to "perform" playfulness, but can inhabit it differently, on quieter, slower, or more critical terms. This requires concepts of play that are sensitive to the affective ecologies of educational life; approaches that do not artificially separate play from everyday norms and values but instead remain sensitive to the ways they continuously cross and blur. Most importantly, it demands sustained critical dialogue among play scholars and educators, one that takes seriously the ethical and political consequences of ignoring these dynamics (Skriver, 2025). Such a dialogue must not only dare to dance with other players, but also with politics itself, recognizing as Nørgård & Whitton (2025, p. 293ff) argue, that truly playful institutions embrace complexity, confrontation, and care as part of their democratic and affective commitments.

The Material Design of Inclusive Playful Learning Through We-Spaces

To make the concept of affective scaffolding more concrete, this section turns to pedagogical experiments in *we-space design.* In one week-long art-pedagogical unit (Skriver, 2024b) held in a forested setting, students were welcomed to a course developed collaboratively by educators. On arrival, students met instructors in Norse-inspired costume and an immersive setting: long communal tables, carved wooden structures and sculptures, moss-covered paths, small ambient fires, and stations for open-ended making. This multisensory entrance marked a deliberate shift from institutional conventions, opening space for new forms of being and relating. The educators set the tone for co-creation by declaring, "This week, we are no longer your instructors, we are co-creators," softening hierarchy while maintaining care.

Participation was paced rather than compelled: observation, touch, or quiet making were valued as initial entries. Natural light, ambient sound, and permission to hold silence slowed exposure. This design enabled emotional multiplicity: students could linger at the margins or engage physically before speaking. Such conditions align with Skovbjerg & Sand's (2022) call for "holding the polyphony" in play spaces, rather than force consensus. Crucially, inclusivity arose not only from educator design but from students' own micro-acts,

like building a fire or initiating song, that oriented bodies toward a greater we and layered care into the social fabric (Skriver, 2024b).

What matters here is not novelty but *ethical play design*, curated tensions between care and provocation, the serious and the ridiculous, the believable and the absurd (Kinch et al., 2025). We-spaces do not dissolve discomfort but make it possible to stay with difficult knowledge (Britzman,1998) without demanding disavowal of one's emotional truths. Scaffolding is built through slowness, sensory richness, relational cues, and the ongoing negotiation of shared presence. They oriented themselves through co-creation, cultivating a slow resonance that spread through the entire group. Students were not asked to "be playful" on cue; they were allowed to orient themselves sensorially—through breath, touch, and silence. This kind of material-affective scaffolding supports entry for those historically mismatched with expectations of spontaneity, improvisation, or extroversion. Inclusion was fostered through careful attention to "affective placeness," the reciprocal relationship between space, bodies, and emotion (Skriver, 2024b).

Ultimately, we-spaces challenge us to think beyond the individual learner and toward the broader design of relational fields. They ask: What does it feel like to enter this space? Who feels held, seen, or disoriented here? Through these questions, affective scaffolding emerges as a deeply political commitment, one that legitimizes the slow, the quiet, and the dissonant as vital modes of participation in communal educational life.

Bridging Pedagogy and Institution: Toward a Scaffolding Ethos

For inclusion to endure, scaffolding must exceed a single classroom. As Nørgaard and Whitton (2025, p. 303) argue, playful institutions cultivate care, communality, and the affective quality of educational relations. They are dialogic by design, sustained through collaboration, and committed to nurturing difference as a resource rather than a disruption. Within such institutions, interpersonal dynamics are not peripheral, rather they are central to sustaining democratic life-affirming learning communities. Playful institutions frame quality and purpose not only through learning outcomes but through values: curiosity, relationality, wonder, and care. In this sense, affective scaffolding is not merely a technique, but a commitment to emotional attentiveness, ethical care, and shared responsibility, capable of holding both dissonance and joy.

Toward a Philosophy of Affective Justice in Play: Designing for Affective Justice

Affective scaffolding reorients educator's role from neutral facilitator to designer of affective conditions attentive to the politics of emotion. This involves:

1. foregrounding emotional difference as a pedagogical resource, rather than a barrier to participation;
2. interrupting dominant affective norms (e.g. humor, spontaneity) as the standard for successful play; and
3. co-creating spaces of invitation, where students can play otherwise— experiment, withhold, disrupt, or linger in the unformed.

In this sense, affective scaffolding is a philosophical stance that affirms the relational and political dimensions of learning, where affect is central to the ethics of inclusion and possibility. It recognizes education as a shared, affectively mediated encounter with difference, history, and becoming. As such, affective scaffolding contributes to an emerging affective justice, a vision of education grounded in the careful, ongoing labor of creating conditions for belonging, dissent, and radical joy.

This vision reframes inclusion as transformation rather than access. It asks educators to redesign not only who is invited, but the affective terms of participation, how learning feels, who belongs, and which forms of play are recognized as legitimate. Such reorientation requires confronting affective norms, often rooted in whiteness and innocence, that govern ease and belonging in classrooms.

Affective justice in education, then, is not an endpoint but an ongoing process of relational, emotional, and ethical negotiation. It is a commitment to *feeling forward*; to crafting learning spaces that are historically attuned, open to dissonance, and capable of sustaining both joy and struggle. It is a call to educators to take seriously the affective conditions of learning, not as background noise, but as the very ground upon which pedagogical possibility is built.

Conclusion

We have argued that play in education must be understood not only as a method or mode of learning but as an affective and political practice that regulates belonging, shapes participation, and can reproduce or resists systemic exclusion. The two vignettes render visible how play may generate ease for some while exacting emotional labor from others. Affective scaffolding advances a design-ethical response: inclusion requires curating atmospheres, rhythms, and recognition practices that legitimate plural participation.

Our contribution is threefold. First, we reframe play as an epistemic and ethical encounter, shaped by emotion, embodiment, and social power. Second, we advance the concept of affective scaffolding as a practical-conceptual tool for designing belonging, co-presence, and plural participation without demanding affective conformity. Third, return to the motif of feeling forward to articulate a vision of education that is not merely inclusive but transformative, where play is not stripped of its affective force but harnessed toward solidarity, co-creation, and justice-to-come.

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Conflict of interest

Authors state no conflict of interest.

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